The rural population, and not the townsfolk, were politically predominant. And they were loyal to the British because this loyalty had been secured by new franchise arrangements. These had accompanied the Land Alienation Act 1900, by virtue of cross-community cooperation and coalition politics. The countryside stood as a discrete entity from the towns. The two were siphoned off from each other. The effect of this was that the Jat peasant farmers of East Punjab, together with their Muslim landlords in the west, shared a common bond as power-holders in resistance to the urban commercial castes. Their anti-urban bias began to be collectively reinforced as their debt rose and the price of the produce fell in the inter-war years. Jat farmers and Muslim landlords both joined the Punjab Unionist Party in a cross-communal grouping. They became a formidable force, so much so that in the 1920s and 1930s peasant unrest fuelled by the Kisan Sabha was overcome by the Punjab Unionist Party as it continued to bolster British rule, reaching its apogee in this regard during the Second World War, when it helped in the recruitment effort. Indeed, as Talbot observes, 'communal violence only spread to the Punjab countryside when the Unionist led collaborative mechanism broke down on the very eve of independence'.[6]

So, British paranoia over the continued stability of the Raj was not unjustified. Swami Dayananda Saraswati called for Swaraj just twenty years after the revolt of 1857. He was the first person in India to do so (not Gandhi). Swaraj, a word which derives from the ancient Indian language of Sanskrit, where *sva* means self, or one's own, and *raj* means rule, had worrying forebodings for the British. Swami Dayananda Saraswati invoked the time-honoured Vedic principle in 1876 with his slogan of 'India for Indians'. This enabled him to form a new political organization, in the form of the reformist Hindu crusade of Arya Samaj. Though a family of Sikhs, Bhagat Singh's grandfather Arjan Singh was a steadfast devotee of Swami, so that he prevented his grandson Bhagat Singh from attending the Khalsa High School in Lahore, which was almost *de rigueur* for all Sikh boys in those days, as the school governors were loyal to the British government. Arjan Singh deplored this to such as extent that he had his grandson enlisted instead at the Dayananda Anglo-Vedic High School, which was a far less